CHAPTER 10 · DEEP DIVE · A HOUSE DIVIDED

The Ku Klux Klan

How organized terror was used as a political weapon to destroy Reconstruction from the shadows. 1866–1871.

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

How organized terror was used as a political weapon to destroy Reconstruction from the shadows. 1866–1871.

When people cannot win at the ballot box, some turn to fear. How does terror work as a political tool — and how do we study it honestly?

Terror With a Purpose

1866

The Ku Klux Klan began in Tennessee in 1866 and spread across the South as the secret, violent arm of white Democrats determined to overthrow Reconstruction. It was not random cruelty — it had a clear political goal.

The Klan's targets were deliberate: Black voters and officeholders, teachers, ministers, and the white Republicans who worked with them. Through night rides, threats, whippings, and murder, they aimed to drive Black citizens from politics and restore white Democratic rule.

Terror in the Night

HARPER'S WEEKLY, 1872

Northern magazines published images of Klan violence to expose it. The hoods and night raids were meant to spread fear — and to let the attackers escape justice.

"Visit of the Ku-Klux" — wood engraving, Harper's Weekly, 1872, public domain (Library of Congress).

Stealing an Election by Fear

THE GOAL: THE VOTE

The Klan's deepest aim was to suppress the Black vote. If Black men were too terrified to go to the polls, white Democrats — the "Redeemers" — could win elections and seize back control of state governments.

It often worked. In county after county, Klan terror in the weeks before an election kept Black voters home and swung results to the Democrats.

Redemption, 1869–77 — map, © ShadowDog Digital Studios (SDS Digital Collection).

Reading the Evidence Carefully

HOW WE KNOW

How do historians study a secret terrorist group? One key source is the congressional testimony of victims and witnesses, gathered in 1871 — hundreds of pages of sworn accounts of what the Klan did.

Studying this history means sourcing carefully: weighing the testimony of victims, the denials of attackers, and the images made by Northern journalists. Each source has a point of view — and the truth comes from reading them together.

A FREEDMAN'S TESTIMONY TO CONGRESS · 1871

They said they were going to kill every … [Black] man that voted the Radical [Republican] ticket.

— CONGRESSIONAL TESTIMONY ON KLAN VIOLENCE

Weigh the Sources

YOUR TURN

You'll examine different sources about the Klan and practice sourcing and point of view — figuring out what the terror was for, and how we can know.